

Start Here



KINGB
KITS

The Candy Bowl Tasting

Your leftovers deserve better

WHAT TO BUY

- **One bag of fun-size variety candy.** That's roughly \$12 and it covers the whole table. The Pairbase names the specific bars that matter.
- **One bottle** for Newbie, two for Casual and Aficionado. Check the Pairbase for your tier before you shop.
- You almost certainly already own a workable bottle. Start there before buying anything.

SET UP

- Unwrap everything and put each candy on its own plate or napkin. Wrappers are loud and they give away the answer.
- Half-ounce pours, not full ones. You're taking three or four sips per pairing, not drinking a glass.
- Water and plain crackers on the table. You'll need the reset more than you expect.

HOW TO TASTE A PAIRING

- **Sip, bite, sip again.** The second sip is the one that matters - that's the pairing talking. The first is just the whisky.
- Let the chocolate melt rather than chewing it. Fat coats the palate, which is exactly what tames a high-proof pour.
- Rinse with water between pairings. Sugar builds up fast and by pairing four everything tastes the same.
- Vote on a winner at the end, and be honest about the worst one. The disasters are the fun part.

IF THERE ARE KIDS AROUND

Run the same cards with cold brew, root beer, or apple cider instead of whisky. The candy side of the pairing works identically and the flavor wheel doesn't care what's in the glass.

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Invitation

Editable Canva template

Set up your RSVP before you send the invite:

1. [Click to copy the RSVP form](#) - your own private copy, replies land in your account, not ours.
2. Click Send in your new form and copy the link, then open the Invitation above, click the QR code, hit Edit, paste your link, and click Update code.

Why Candy and Whisky Agree

The overlap is real chemistry, not a party trick.

What's Actually In There

Five ingredients do almost all the work.

Milk chocolate

Cocoa butter, milk solids and sugar. The fat physically coats your palate, which blunts alcohol burn. This is why chocolate makes a cask-strength pour suddenly drinkable.

Caramel

Cooked sugar produces the same browning compounds that form when a barrel is charred. Caramel candy and bourbon are, in a real sense, tasting of the same reaction.

Coconut

Rich in lactones - the exact compound class American oak gives bourbon. An Almond Joy against a bourbon is a straight compound match, which is why it lands so hard.

Malt and nougat

Malted barley in nougat and malted-milk candy shares its base ingredient with single malt. Same grain, different end of the process.

Salt

Suppresses bitterness and boosts perceived sweetness. It's why salted peanut candy flatters oak tannin instead of fighting it.

The Two Kinds of Pairing

● Complement

Shared compounds. Caramel candy with a caramel-forward bourbon. Comfortable, obvious, and the right place to start. This is the Newbie card.

● Contrast

Opposing forces that hold each other up. Bitter dark chocolate against peat smoke. Salt against sweet. Riskier, and far more interesting when it lands. This is the Casual card.

● Collision

Acid, anise and raw sugar - the three things whisky handles worst. Mostly bad, occasionally astonishing. This is the Aficionado card.

THE THREE DIFFICULT ONES

Sour candy. Citric and malic acid strip the palate and clash hard with oak tannin. Genuinely useful as a reset between pairings; rarely good as a pairing itself.

Black licorice. Anethole, the anise compound. Fights almost everything, then works unreasonably well with heavily peated Islay.

Candy corn. Effectively sugar, honey and vanilla with no fat to carry it. Nothing tames it. Expect an argument at the table, which is the whole reason it's on the card.

What to Pour Against What

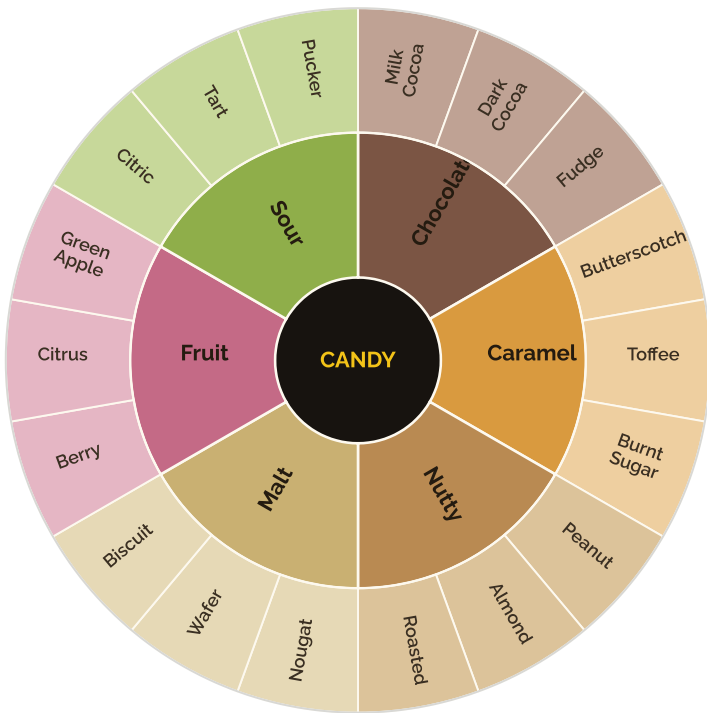
Every bottle here is common and under \$70.

CANDY	WHY IT WORKS	WHISKY STYLE	TRY THESE BOTTLES	PER BOTTLE	PAIRING TYPE
Snickers	Caramel and roasted peanut meet barrel char head-on.	Caramel-forward bourbon	Evan Williams Bottled-in-Bond Four Roses Small Batch	\$16–20	Complement
Twix	Cookie and caramel echo oak and vanilla almost exactly.	Standard bourbon	Buffalo Trace Eagle Rare 10	\$25–30	Complement
Milky Way	Malted nougat shares its base grain with the whisky.	Sweeter bourbon or Speyside	Jim Beam Black Glenlivet 12	\$22–27	Complement
Kit Kat	Wafer and malt echo grain - gentler than the bourbon-heavy picks.	Blended or lighter Speyside scotch	Dewar's 12 Chivas Regal 12	\$24–29	Complement
Almond Joy	Coconut lactones are the same compounds American oak donates.	Rye, or a rum-cask finish	Rittenhouse Rye Wild Turkey 101	\$22–26	Complement
Reese's	Salt suppresses bitterness and lifts the sweetness underneath.	Wheated bourbon	Maker's Mark Larceny	\$28–33	Contrast
Dark chocolate	Cocoa bitterness and peat smoke cancel each other's edges.	Peated Islay	Highland Park 12 Laphroaig 10	\$45–55	Contrast
Sour Patch Kids	Acid strips the palate. Best used as a reset, not a pairing.	Anything, briefly	Use between pairings not as one	-	Collision
Black licorice	Anise fights everything except heavy peat, where it sings.	Heavily peated scotch	Ardbeg 10 Laphroaig 10	\$50–58	Collision
Candy corn	Pure sugar with no fat to carry it. Nothing tames it.	Irish, if anything	Jameson good luck	\$22–28	Collision

Shopping math. One \$12 bag of fun-size variety candy plus one bottle you likely already own covers a table of six. **This is the cheapest tasting night you will ever host**, which makes it the easiest one to actually schedule.

Find the Overlap

Where the two wheels share a word, the pairing usually works.



Candy



Whisky

Using the wheels: name what's in the candy, then name what's in the glass. **Caramel, Nutty and Malt appear on both wheels** - those overlaps are your safe pairings. Sour appears on only one, which tells you everything about why sour candy is so hard to pair.

Newbie

The Sweet Match

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THREE CANDIES · ONE BOURBON · LIKE PAIRED WITH LIKE

The question: what does it feel like when a pairing *agrees*? Every candy here shares a flavor compound with the whisky. Nothing fights. This is your baseline for everything after.

 TASTER

DATE

PAIRING 1

Sip · bite · sip again

Snickers



Whisky poured _____

PAIRING 2

Sip · bite · sip again

Twix



Whisky poured _____

PAIRING 3

Sip · bite · sip again

Milky Way



Whisky poured _____

WINNER OF THE NIGHT

WORST PAIRING (BE HONEST)

Casual

The Contrast

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THREE CANDIES · TWO WHISKIES · OPPOSITES ON PURPOSE

The question: can a pairing work by *fighting*? Dark chocolate against peat smoke should be a train wreck and isn't. Salt against sweet should be too much and isn't. Find out where the line is.

 TASTER

DATE

PAIRING 1

Sip · bite · sip again

Dark Chocolate + Peated Scotch



Whisky poured _____

PAIRING 2

Sip · bite · sip again

Reese's + Wheated Bourbon



Whisky poured _____

PAIRING 3

Sip · bite · sip again

Almond Joy + Rye



Whisky poured _____

WINNER OF THE NIGHT

WORST PAIRING (BE HONEST)

THE DIFFICULT CANDY · THE ONES NOBODY PAIRS ON PURPOSE

The question: what actually survives? Acid, anise and pure sugar are the three things whisky handles worst. Something here will surprise you and something will be genuinely unpleasant. Both are the point.

 TASTER

DATE

PAIRING 1

Acid vs oak

Sour Patch Kids

Whisky poured _____

PAIRING 2

Anise vs peat

Black Licorice

Whisky poured _____

PAIRING 3

Pure sugar vs everything

Candy Corn

Whisky poured _____

WINNER OF THE NIGHT

WORST PAIRING (BE HONEST)

Everything on the list, then close the night with a real ballot.

PAIRING NIGHT SCORECARD

- Pass around at the end of the night. Whichever pairing gets the most votes is next Halloween's starting point.

[illegible]

Right glass for the table. A plain rocks glass or short tumbler works for every tier and doubles as the kids' cup for cold brew or cider - no need to buy two sets of glassware.